

Chapter 5

Getting Started: The Beginning Stage and Beginning Phase

The First Session

The first and second sessions of any group are often the most important and usually are the most difficult to lead; *therefore you should read this chapter more than once*. The first session is difficult because the leader has many different dynamics and logistics to manage: starting the group, introducing the members, introducing the content to the members, and monitoring the members' reactions both to being in the group and to the content. We discuss 19 different concepts to consider in the first session.

1. Beginning the group
2. Helping members get acquainted
3. Setting a positive tone
4. Clarifying the purpose of the group
5. Explaining the leader's role
6. Explaining how the group will be conducted
7. Helping members verbalize expectations
8. Drawing out members
9. Using exercises
10. Checking out the comfort levels of the members

11. Explaining group rules
12. Explaining any special terms that will be used
13. Assessing members' interaction styles
14. Being sensitive to multicultural and diversity issues and any dynamics that may be present
15. Focusing on the content
16. Cutting off members
17. Addressing questions
18. Getting members to look at other members
19. Closing the first session

Beginning the Group

One of the most important considerations for the first session is how to begin the group. How the leader opens the session will have a bearing on the tone of the group and the comfort level of the members. The leader should convey warmth, trust, helpfulness, understanding, and positive regard. This is the time when members form their impressions of the leader and assess whether or not they think the group is going to be helpful to them.

Unfortunately, members sometimes quit groups that could be helpful because the opening few minutes were boring or intimidating and they tuned out the leader. Others may be put off if the leader inappropriately uses a formal, businesslike manner in the opening moments. For some groups, a formal or firm opening is appropriate, but for most groups it is less effective. Some leaders make the mistake of opening with a mini-lecture and discussion on issues such as the rules, the meeting time for each session, and the frequency of meetings. When 10 or 15 minutes are spent discussing these issues, many members are bored. Another common mistake is allowing the introduction of members to take too long. Some beginning leaders are afraid to cut off members, so they politely let each member go on for 3 or 4 minutes—this makes for a boring opening for most groups. *Remember, the opening few minutes of a first session are very important!*

Following are eight possible openings that include an overview of the group and the introduction of members.

Options for Opening the First Session 1. *Start with a brief statement about the group; then conduct an introduction exercise.* This type of opening is perhaps the one most frequently used by leaders. The leader gives a brief (1- to 2-minute), well-thought-out opening statement and then has the members participate in an introduction exercise. This prevents members from settling into a "listening" frame of mind; they become active almost immediately and quickly feel that they are participants in a group rather than listeners in a class. This opening is especially useful for groups where the members do not know each other.

EXAMPLE

The group is for teenagers whose parents have divorced or separated in the last 4 months.

LEADER: I'm really glad you are here. As you know, this group is for sharing thoughts, feelings, and reactions to your parents' divorce or separation. It is my understanding that each of you has experienced your parents either divorcing or separating within the last 4 months. Through this group, I hope you will realize that you're not the only one feeling the way you do. Having your parents split up causes all kinds of feelings—chances are many of you are having a variety of those feelings. We'll explore them in this group. To get started, I thought we'd do an introductory exercise to learn about each other. I am going to ask each of you to share your name, how long your parents have been divorced or separated, and with whom you are currently living. We'll go around the group. Who wants to start?

TED: I will. I am Ted. My parents are definitely going to divorce or at least I think so. Last week—

LEADER: *(Using a caring voice)* Ted, let me interrupt. For now, just share how long they've been separated and with whom you are living.

TED: Sorry. I am Ted, and I am living with my mom. They separated 4 weeks ago.

MELINDA: I am Melinda ...

2. *Start with a long opening statement about the group and its purpose; then conduct an introduction exercise.* This type of opening is often used for education or task groups, although some leaders use a long opening statement for therapy and growth groups as well. The leader will spend the first 3 to 5 minutes describing the purpose and format of the group in a pleasant, energetic manner, and then he will present an overview of the planned content for another couple of minutes. During this opening, the leader will usually give some background information about himself and his experience in leading groups. A practical reason for using a long opening is to capture the interest of the members who are present when other members have not yet arrived. It is important to understand that a long opening statement must be interesting and informative for the members. If it is boring, the leader can lose the members for the entire session. On numerous occasions, we have heard of leaders who talked for 10 to 15 minutes at the beginning—this would be a major mistake.

EXAMPLE

The group consists of teachers in a large school district. It is the first session in a series of four on teacher burnout.

LEADER: I'd like us to begin. I am Sarah Daniels. I am a counselor at North High School. Over the last several years, I have been studying teacher burnout. As a result of my studies, I have developed what I think is a helpful way of understanding burnout. Over the next 4 weeks, I will be going over the material. Briefly, I'd like to share what each session will be about. Today we will start by ... *(After going over the material for 2 or 3 minutes, the leader concludes the opening statement.)*

LEADER: I hope you now have an idea of what will take place here and how this group can help. Now, before getting started with definitions of burnout, I'd like to take a couple of minutes and let you introduce yourselves. I'd like each of you to tell us your name, how long you have been teaching, what you teach, and a sentence or two about why you came.

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3. *Start with a long opening statement; then get right into the content of the group.* This opening can be used in discussion, education, and task groups where the members already know each other or in groups where personal sharing will be minimal. A long opening statement is used when the leader feels the members need an explanation or clarification of the group's content or purpose. The long opening statement would be similar to that in Option 2 above, where the leader outlines the content and shares some information about himself. It differs from Option 2 in that the leader does not plan an introduction of the members because the members know each other or because the group is too large.

■ EXAMPLE

The group is for helping 14 unemployed people find jobs. The leader opens the session.

LEADER: I am glad you decided to attend the group. I think you will find the information helpful in getting you back into the workforce. The goal of these group sessions will be to give you information about finding potential jobs, interviewing for jobs, filling out applications, and keeping a positive attitude while looking. Before we get started, I want to tell you a little about myself and about each of the five sessions.... *(After going over the proposed content of the 5five sessions, the leader continues.)*

LEADER: Now, let's get started on today's material. We're going to discuss how to find potential jobs. I want each of you to think of three ways that you go about looking for work and then list those on a sheet of paper.

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4. *Start with a brief statement about the group; then get into the content.* This opening would be used when no introductions are needed (members already

know each other) and the purpose of the group is already clear to the members. This is a good opening for many discussion, education, and task groups, especially if they are meeting for a short period, such as an hour.

EXAMPLE

The group's purpose is to decide on policies for a new treatment unit for adolescents. The leader begins.

LEADER: Let's get started. We have a number of policies to decide on regarding the new unit. The current plan is to meet each Tuesday for an hour and a half at this time for the next 4 weeks or until we feel we are finished. Why don't we begin by listing the kinds of policies we think need to be written? I'll write them as you call them out.

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5. *Start with a brief statement about the group; then have the members form dyads.* Leaders can use this opening when no introduction exercise is necessary. The leader describes the group briefly and then has members form dyads to discuss either the content of the group or why they have come to the group. This kind of opening is useful when the purpose is already clear to everyone and the members are reasonably comfortable being in the group. It is also useful in certain kinds of task, education, discussion, and support groups.

EXAMPLE

This is a group for students who are thinking about dropping out of school.

LEADER: I am so glad that you all agreed to come to this group. I am hoping that all of you will benefit from some aspect of our group and hopefully you will find support here for whatever decision you make about school. It is, after all, one of the most important decisions you will make in your life. Let's do this: because you all know each other, I would like for you to pair up with a partner and just share how you are feeling about the thought of dropping out and what your feelings are about staying in school. Also talk about what you would like to gain from attending this group.

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6. *Start with a brief statement about the group; then have members fill out a short sentence-completion form.* When no introductions are needed, using a sentence-completion form is an excellent way to open certain kinds of groups because it tends to help members focus. This kind of opening is helpful in leading task groups, discussion groups, and some education groups. It can also be used in growth and therapy groups when the members already know one another.

EXAMPLE

The group's purpose is to improve staff relations in a military unit.

LEADER: As you know, the purpose of this meeting is to improve working relations within the unit. I'd like to start by having you fill out this form, which consists of five incomplete sentences.

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7. *Start with an introduction exercise.* Starting with an introduction exercise instead of a statement about the group should be done only when the members have a clear idea of the group's purpose. If an appropriate introduction exercise is used, this type of opening can serve a dual purpose: Members can introduce themselves and begin immediately to focus on the content of the group. The leader would make some comments to further clarify the purpose of the group and how it is going to be conducted.

EXAMPLE

This is a support group for single fathers.

LEADER: Why don't we begin? As a way of starting, I'd like each of you to introduce yourself and tell us the age of your child or children and in two or three sentences how you came to be a single father. Who wants to go first?

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8. *Start with an unusual opening—one that grabs the members.* There are times when the leader may want to use a creative beginning to get the members' attention, especially if the leader believes that members may not be committed to being in the group. These openings can be interesting and can set a good tone for the session. We have purposely been a little late and harried to start a group on the topic of time management. We have staged a brief, heated verbal exchange before the group began when we were going to teach communications. After the "fight," we get members to talk about what they saw and felt and then introduce the idea of people coming from different ego states. Then we would do the more formal introduction about the group, rules, names, and so on. The point is that leaders may want to use a creative opening to get members' attention and hook their interest.

These examples illustrate that there are a variety of appropriate ways to open a first session. *Remember, the right kind of opening, combined with enthusiasm on the part of the leader, will have a strong positive effect on how a group starts.*

Helping Members Get Acquainted

In a first session, the leader will want to consider how members will get more comfortable with one another. If members do not know each other, it is usually

beneficial to have them get acquainted soon after the session begins. Members tend to feel more at ease after learning each others' names and spending some time getting to know each other.

The amount of time spent on introductions varies according to the purpose. In groups where personal sharing will take place, more time should be spent helping members get to know one another because members are curious about those with whom they will be discussing personal issues. In most education and discussion groups and in many task groups, only a minimal amount of time needs to be spent on introductions because members either know one another or will not be discussing personal issues. In groups consisting of members from diverse cultural backgrounds, more time will probably be needed to help members get comfortable.

The size of the group can limit the options for the kind of introduction exercise chosen. If the group has more than 10 members, the leader will probably not want to use an introduction exercise involving each member sharing about himself or herself for 1 to 2 minutes because it would take too long. When groups are meeting for a rather short period (an hour or less), the leader will not want to use any introduction exercise that lasts more than 5 minutes. This applies especially to education, discussion, and task groups, and to groups meeting for only one session.

The purpose of the group is probably the most important factor in determining what kind of introduction exercise to use. For instance, it would not be relevant for a leader of a group for cancer patients to have an introduction activity where the members share the names of their family members, where they work, and their favorite hobby. Instead, the leader could have the members state their names, how long they have been receiving treatment, and one fear or feeling about having the disease.

The following are descriptions of several introduction activities.

The Name Round The name round is probably the most frequently used exercise for learning people's names. In the name round, members simply introduce themselves, sometimes giving names only, but most of the time sharing additional information. Naturally, what is shared will depend on the purpose of the group. For instance, in a parenting group, the leader would have members state the number of children they have and their ages, and maybe one concern they want to address in the group; in a changing families group for children, members could tell how long their parents have been divorced, with whom they live, and maybe a word or phrase regarding how they feel about their parents' divorce.

One common mistake of beginning leaders is to have members share irrelevant information. We have heard stories of members being asked to introduce themselves and tell various irrelevant things about themselves. Most members of serious groups are not interested in "cute" openings. A "fun" introduction activity is appropriate for certain kinds of groups (school or church retreats, social groups for the elderly), but it is a mistake to use a light introduction exercise for groups that have a serious purpose—for example, groups dealing with such issues as abuse, addiction, AIDS, anger, or rape. Another mistake is to let members

share for too long, thus turning the introduction of members into a 15- to 20-minute activity that tends to get boring.

The Repeat Round The repeat round is a name exercise where the first member says her name, the next member says the first member's name and then his name, and so on. This exercise is good for helping members remember everyone's name. School kids tend to like this, and it does help with learning the names.

The Introduction Dyad This activity consists of two members pairing up and telling each other certain things about themselves, usually based on suggestions from the leader. Then all the members come back together in a group, and each one introduces his partner to the group. For example, in a group for children who have trouble making friends, a member might say, "This is Carlos. He likes football and fishing. He has two younger stepbrothers. His favorite subject in school is math." With this exercise, members focus on listening and getting to know one other member better.

The Repeated Dyad Members pair up with every other member and spend 2 to 5 minutes sharing such things as why they are in the group and what they hope to gain. (This is good for certain kinds of support, growth, and therapy groups.) This exercise should be used only when there are fewer than seven members and the session is at least an hour and a half long; otherwise, it would take too much time to allow each member to form a dyad with every other member.

Milling For large groups (12 or more members), we sometimes have members mill around and meet each other during the first 4 to 5 minutes of the first group session. The instructions are usually quite simple, such as, "To help you get acquainted, I'd like you to stand up and mill about the room meeting the other group members. Try to learn everyone's name and why he or she is here." A simple activity like this provides an opportunity for members to have contact with one another and speeds up the process of getting acquainted. This is especially good when the leader is waiting for a couple of members to arrive and the others are sitting quietly by themselves.

These are just some of the ways a leader can help members get acquainted. It is important that the leader always consider how introductions are going to be handled. A good introduction exercise is one that is appropriate for the kind of group and the amount of time the group is meeting. *Using large name tags is probably the easiest way to help members remember the names of other members.*

Setting a Positive Tone

Another important task for the leader during the first and second sessions is to establish a positive tone for the group. The tone is the prevailing atmosphere; it stems from several sources, including the leader's enthusiasm and the members'

comfort and trust. The leader can establish a positive tone by being enthusiastic and drawing out members, cutting off hostile or negative interactions, holding the focus on interesting topics, and shifting the focus when the topics are irrelevant or only interesting to a couple of members.

It is very important that the leader not let the group focus on negative members or negative issues for a major portion of the first session. A member who is complaining about being in the group or questioning its value can establish a negative tone that may be difficult to alter. Allowing extended hostile or heated interaction between members also contributes to a negative tone. Certainly some time may have to be devoted to these dynamics, but the leader will want to make sure that most of the time is spent sharing and discussing in a positive way. If a negative tone is set during the first two group sessions, members will usually never come to trust one another enough to share personal information. They may feel that the group is a place to "nail" other members, causing them to either focus on others or fear being attacked by the group.

Setting a good tone for nonvoluntary groups is very important. Leaders of nonvoluntary groups need to be prepared for uncooperative and hostile members who may try to set a negative tone. Also, the leader may need to be rather firm but also show concern and understanding. When leading a nonvoluntary group, the leader will want to have an opening that gets the members' attention and gets them interested immediately. One group leader we know put a garbage can in the center of a group for teenagers who had been caught using alcohol at school and said something like, "I know you don't want to be here, so I want you to get all your complaints out now and then we'll put a lid on them. You have 10 minutes to complain." At the end of that 10 minutes, she stopped them, put the lid on the trash can, and said, "Let's name our group," which ended up being called "The Beach Group"—and they were nowhere near a beach! This got the group off to an interesting start and got members involved and curious. She also made it clear she was in charge.

A good leader gives much thought to the tone he wants to set. Below are some Dos and Don'ts for setting the tone.

Do

- Get everyone to share
- Be enthusiastic
- Be warm and inviting
- Be creative for nonvoluntary groups
- Get control early and let people see you are in charge and you know what you are doing

Don't

- Let the group focus on negative issues at the beginning of the session
- Let one member dominate

- Start with boring group rules
- Let members attack each other
- Come across as authoritarian or demanding



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: How to Conduct a First Session

Go to videos on "How to Conduct a First Session" (5.1, 5.2, 5.3). Watch a discussion and three demonstrations of beginning a group. You will see three different leaders use a variety of techniques for beginning a first session. Pay careful attention to how they set the tone, help members get acquainted, and how they get briefly into the content or purpose of the group. Note in video 5.2 how the leader covers some leadership skills and confidentiality in the first minute but does it in a way that is not boring.

Clarifying the Purpose

The leader wants to be sure that the purpose of the group is clarified during the first and second sessions. Clarification is particularly important if there has been no screening interview. Even if the leader has screened the members and has already spent time discussing the group's purpose, it is still a good idea to review the purpose in the group. The purpose of some groups may require more clarification than others. A group that has been advertised as a divorce group could be intended for support or therapy. Therefore, the specific purpose of the group will have to be clarified during the first session.

For any group where the purpose may be confusing, it is a good idea to reiterate the purpose throughout the first two sessions. After the second session, it usually is not necessary to review the purpose unless new members are added to the group or the purpose changes during the life of the group.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Clarifying the Purpose in First Sessions

Review videos 3.2 and 3.3 to see how the leader clarifies the purpose of the group to the members.

Explaining the Leader's Role

During the first session, the leader should explain what her role will be throughout the sessions: a teaching role, a facilitative role, an active leadership role, a therapeutic role, or some of each. Offering an explanation helps members form a picture of what to expect from the leader.

EXAMPLES

Example 1 Leader: Let me take just a minute to explain my role to all of you. As you know, for the next 6 weeks, we will be meeting every Monday evening so that you can share your experience as a single parent. My role in this group will be to facilitate sharing and provide some information. On some occasions, the situation may call for me to become more active and lead the group in counseling a member who is asking the group for some help.

Example 2 Leader: In this group, I mainly will help you share any problems you are having here at school, at home, or with your friends. I will make sure that this is a safe place to share any concerns you have and will help you learn how to problem solve. I will encourage you to share and will ask you to do some different kinds of group exercises that will help you focus on different areas of your life, such as problems with parents, peer pressure, or problems with schoolwork.

Example 3 Leader: In this group, I will introduce you to the dangers of alcohol and drug use. To do this, I will present some information and then get you to share reactions, thoughts, and questions. I will mostly be trying to get you to express your thoughts and concerns and will not be teaching like a teacher does, where all you have to do is sit and listen. This is meant to be a group for sharing so I will be asking all of you to participate.

Example 4 Leader: My role in this group is to see to it you make the decisions that need to be made. My participation will be minimal; that is, I will not offer my opinion or ideas because I do not work here and do not know your agency as well as you do. I will encourage you to be open and honest with each other, and I will try to get you to express how you feel about the issues. Also, I will try to structure the time wisely so we can accomplish something each time we meet.

Explaining How the Group Will Be Conducted

Closely aligned to explaining the purpose and the leader's role is explaining what will happen during a session. Leaders should clarify during the first session how they plan to conduct the group. The leader will help ease tension and ensure the smooth functioning of the group if she describes the kinds of discussions and activities that will take place in the group. If there is a specific format for the group, the leader would want to explain this.

EXAMPLE

LEADER: Each session we will spend the first few minutes sharing comments or any relevant experiences since our last meeting. We'll then focus on anything that one of you wants to talk about. If no one has anything for that day, we'll focus on a new topic. We'll split our time between discussing different concerns you have and topics that we decide we want to cover. We'll always spend the last few minutes sharing what we got out of the session and offering encouragement to each other.

In certain kinds of groups, the leader will want to inform members that they will be asked to do certain group exercises and that, at times, the group may get rather intense. Also, he may want to explain how he intends to work with individuals who bring up concerns they want to work on. Hearing this explanation during the first and second sessions will give members a much clearer understanding of what will take place in the group.

A good reason for stating what will happen in the group is that, after hearing a description, some members may decide they do not want to be in the group. If a member decides to leave the group, the leader will want to determine the reason. Depending on the reason, the leader may or may not encourage the member to stay. That is, the leader would not want to urge a member to stay who definitely wanted a different kind of group, but she might try to encourage a member who feared that something bad might happen to him in the group. Usually the discussion with the member wanting to quit is done in private, but sometimes the leader may see the value of discussing it with the entire group.

Included in the discussion of how the group will be conducted should also be a discussion of the potential risks involved in being in a support, growth, counseling, or therapy group because groups can present life-changing experiences. The ASGW *Guidelines for Best Practice* (2008) specifies that leaders are responsible for explaining and discussing the risks of being in a group. Members need to know they may discover uncomfortable things about themselves or their pasts. Also, they need to be informed that they will be challenged to look at how they see themselves, how they cope, and how they interact with others.

Helping Members Verbalize Expectations

One first-session activity that is beneficial for certain kinds of groups is to have members share their expectations of the group. In this way, the leader learns what the members want, and he can further clarify the purpose of the group by commenting. At times, the leader will expand upon some of the expectations voiced if they are in line with the purpose. At other times, the leader will need to point out that certain expectations will not be met by the current group because of its structure and purpose.

EXAMPLE

This group is for teenage girls who have had a baby in the last 3 months. The leader has just finished an introduction exercise and decides to use a round to get members to verbalize their expectations. Note also how the leader comments on some of the expectations as they apply to the group.

LEADER: Okay, now that we know a little more about each other, I want to talk about your expectations for the group. I want you each to think of what you are hoping to get from the group. We'll go around and hear from each of you.

ANGELA: I just look forward to talking to kids my own age about having a baby. Talking to grown-ups all the time isn't fun.

LEADER: Certainly one of the main reasons for the group is just that—all of you will get a chance to share with one another, and you do have things in common, that's for sure.

DONNA: I am overwhelmed. Trying to handle the baby, school, my boyfriend, friends! I don't know if I can do it, and I hope to get some ideas.

LEADER: I think all of you will find that the group can really be of help. I think each one of us has some ideas that can help others, and that's the benefit of the six of us meeting.

NELDA: I came because it sounded like something I could learn from.

TANDY: I need help with my baby! I am scared that I will screw up my kid, and I don't want to do that.

LEADER: We will spend some time each week talking about child rearing because I think each of you probably wants to hear about that.

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Sometimes members attend a first session having expectations that are not in line with the purpose of the group. If this situation arises, the leader will want to reiterate the purpose. If a member remains insistent that the purpose should be different, the leader may have members get into pairs and discuss why they came or some other relevant question while the leader pairs up with the insistent member—this avoids a long discussion or debate in front of the group that may create a negative tone.

EXAMPLES

In this first example, the member has an expectation that is not in line with the group's purpose, which is to help first-year college students with study skills. The students are expressing their expectations.

BUD: I want to learn how to prepare for essay exams. My high school was such a breeze, and all my tests were fill-in-the-blank or multiple choice.

AKIRA: I need help with my math problems—I don't understand equations, and the instructor said I should get a tutor, so when I saw the announcement about a study skills group, I thought I would give it a try.

LEADER: Well, Akira, let me clarify something for you and for others. This group is not really for tutoring as much as it is for teaching you how to study. That is, we will not work on any specific course but we will talk about how to study for certain courses, including math. I guess what I am saying is that, if any of you are looking for specific help in a course, then probably a tutor would be better. We are going to talk about how to take notes, how to prepare for exams, and basically how to study. Akira, now that you are here, you may want to stay, or you may really just be looking for math help. If you want a tutor, I'll help you with that after the group today.

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In this example, one member's expectations are different from the others'. The purpose of the group is for parents to discuss what to do about the many teen pregnancies in the community. Members are discussing their views of the goal of the group.

CARLA: I think it's good that we are meeting. I don't want my daughter to become pregnant, but I don't know the best way to prevent it. So I am hoping that as a group we can come up with some good ideas for educating our kids about sex.

BETSY: That's why I came—to try to come up with something that either the school or community can do.

DOT: I can tell you what we have to do, and that's to stop these kids from having abortions! They gave some statistics about teenage abortions on television that horrified me. I am here to see to it that the school does something about all these abortions!

LEADER: I really don't see this group as focusing on abortions. The purpose of this group is to decide how to prevent so many from getting pregnant.

DOT: I can't buy that. It is our moral duty to stop kids from even considering abortion!

LEADER: *(In a very calm voice)* Let's do this: I want you to pair up with someone you don't know very well and discuss what you think are the different topics that we need to discuss in this group. Dot, I'll be with you.

The leader could tell that Dot was not going to let the issue die, and he did not want the group to focus on a side issue. By using dyads, the leader was able to keep members focused while talking to Dot about the purpose. The leader would want to be careful not to spend the next half hour trying to convince Dot of the purpose. He probably should not spend more than 5 minutes if for no other reason than the other members will likely run out of things to say. This is a situation where the leader might ask Dot to leave if she insists on talking about the abortion issue.

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A leader can make several mistakes regarding the expectations of the members. Some leaders spend as much as half or three-fourths of a session on the question, "What do you hope to get from this group?" This usually happens when expectations are varied and the leader feels obligated to discuss each one. Probably no more than 8 or 10 minutes should be spent on expectations, and often they can be covered in 5 minutes or less. *A very common mistake leaders make is to ask members for their expectations when they really don't have any.* This can be the case in groups where the members are required to attend or are attending in order to avoid some other activity, such as class or work. The leader may want to ask about expectations but should be prepared for little or no response—or responses that are not in line with the purpose.

EXAMPLE

This is a mandatory group at a 30-day juvenile crisis center.

LEADER: I'd like to hear from each of you about why you are in the group and what you hope to gain from it.

DON: Hey, man, I don't want anything—they made me come.

ALTON: There's nothing the matter with me—I hate this group therapy crap!

LEADER: This isn't crap. Hopefully, it will be helpful.

MEL: I want to talk about rock music—the houseparent said we can talk about anything.

LEADER: Come on, be serious. What can you get from this group?

The leader should not have mentioned expectations or should have expected some negative reactions because the members did not volunteer for the group. The leader did not second-guess that there probably would not be many expectations. A better way to handle this would be to mention if anyone had expectations and then quickly move to an interesting exercise rather than pushing the idea of expectations.

Drawing Out Members During the First Session

It is advisable that the leader, during the first and second sessions, makes sure that everyone has a chance to contribute. The leader should not force each member to speak; rather, members should feel they may participate if they so desire. If the members believe they haven't had an opportunity to verbalize their thoughts, feelings, or ideas, they may feel left out.

During the first session of a growth, counseling, therapy, or support group, the leader should, if at all possible, get each member to share something because this tends to reduce anxiety about being in the group. It is also important because members are usually curious about each other, and disclosures usually

help members feel more comfortable. Be aware, however, that some members will be so uncomfortable or fearful that they will not share very much during the first meeting.

Two of the best ways to get members to share during the first session are the use of written exercises and rounds. Introduction rounds, other rounds, and some written exercises usually will get each member to comment. Written exercises, such as sentence completions or lists, are excellent activities because members usually will feel fairly comfortable when asked to share what they have written.

Use of Exercises During the First Session

During the first session, certain exercises can be used to create comfort, interest, and member involvement. We discuss three exercises below: rounds, dyads, and sentence completions.

1. *Rounds* are the most valuable exercise that we use in the first session because they get everyone to speak, which is important. Earlier in this chapter, we mentioned the *name round*. Other rounds are 1–10 scales on some issue or feeling, such as level of comfort in the group, commitment to being in the group, how it feels to work in a certain occupation, or how much stress members feel in their lives. We cover rounds in-depth in Chapter 9.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: How to Use Rounds in First Sessions

In each of the three videos showing the beginning of a group (5.1, 5.2 and 5.3) the leaders used rounds in various ways to get members to share information about themselves. You may want to review these videos again and pay attention to how the leader used rounds to facilitate discussion.

2. *Dyads* (pairs) are very valuable in the beginning stage of groups because they give members the opportunity to talk more personally with one other member, creating a more comfortable atmosphere and often energizing them for talking in front of the whole group. Members can be paired with one another to discuss their reactions, feelings, ideas, answers, or some other relevant point. Common mistakes with the use of dyads include letting them last too long or doing too many in one session. Dyads rarely should last more than 5 minutes because long dyads do not allow members to have contact with others, and the leader cannot be sure how members are going to connect because they don't know each other. A member may feel annoyed or intimidated by his or her partner and thus conclude that the group is not helpful.

Any leader deciding to use dyads must first consider whether the members will have something meaningful to say. That is, in nonvoluntary groups, groups where the purpose is confusing, or groups with young children and teenagers, the members may have little to say, so using dyads would be a mistake.

3. *Sentence-completion exercises* have also proved very helpful in facilitating interaction during the first session. This kind of written exercise gives members a base from which to comment. Also, members are usually very interested in hearing how others responded to the same incomplete sentence. The following are examples of sentence stems that could be used.

- In a new group, I feel most comfortable when _____.
- In a new group, I am most afraid of _____.
- In a new group, I will usually _____.

For a group with military wives:

- The hardest thing about my husband being deployed is _____.
- The thing I worry most about _____.
- One way I cope is _____.

For a group of elementary school children whose parents are divorced:

- The hardest thing about my parents' divorce is _____.
- The person I blame the most for the divorce is _____.
- When I think of my parents' divorce, I am most angry about _____.

These are just a few examples of exercises that may be helpful during the first session. Certainly other exercises—written, experiential, or verbal—are beneficial. The leader should always keep in mind when selecting exercises for the first session that their purpose is usually to help members get acquainted and feel comfortable or to focus on the content in a meaningful but not too intense way. Some leaders make the mistake of presenting one exercise right after another, which does not leave much time for interaction or for processing the exercises, and it gives the members the impression that the group is about doing exercises rather than interaction and sharing.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: Use of Sentence Completion in a First Session

View again video 5.3 and watch how the leader uses a sentence completion exercise to get members talking about their lives.

Checking Out the Comfort Level

Feeling apprehensive or uncomfortable during the first session of a support, growth, counseling, or therapy group is quite common. To help reduce this discomfort, the leader might spend a few minutes focused on the topic of comfort level. By inquiring about members' comfort levels, the leader lets members know he is aware that there may be some anxiety and that it is to be expected. In addition, hearing that others are anxious often eases members' anxiety by

showing them they are not alone. The leader may want to introduce the topic of comfort during the warm-up phase—that is, within the first half-hour—if members seem extremely uncomfortable. If the leader does not discuss comfort in the beginning, he can introduce it almost any time throughout the session by saying something like, "Let's focus for a few minutes on the topic of comfort in this group," then using any of the following:

- In terms of comfort in the group right now, what is the word or phrase that best describes how you are feeling?
- On a 1–10 scale, with 10 being very uncomfortable and 1 being very comfortable, how would you rate how you are feeling in the group right now?
- On a 1–10 scale, with 10 being very uncomfortable and 1 being very comfortable, how would you rate how you were feeling in the group when we started, and how would you rate how you're feeling now?
- Does anyone want to comment on how he or she is feeling about being in this group?
- I'd like you to pair up with a person whom you would like to get to know better and talk about how you feel about being in the group. Discuss your comfort level and why you feel the way you do. Naturally, some of you are more comfortable than others. You'll have about 3 minutes to do this; then we'll come back to the large group for discussion.

Any of these activities will help members talk about the comfort level in the group. Such discussions often help members feel more comfortable, both through sharing their feelings and hearing that others feel some discomfort. The leader also gains a better idea of the source of discomfort. The leader may choose not to draw out those who rate themselves as very uncomfortable because focusing on them could make them more so.

Explaining Group Rules

There are a number of things to consider regarding rules for the group: what the rules should be, who makes the rules, when to discuss them, and how to discuss them.

What should the rules be? All groups have rules about attendance; tardiness; being reasonably cooperative and sensitive to others; one person talking at a time; and eating, smoking, and drinking during the session. Most counseling, therapy, support, and growth groups have rules about attacking others, putting others on the spot, and keeping shared personal disclosures confidential.

Who makes the rules? In most cases the leader makes the rules because the leader understands groups and what rules need to be in place for the group to be successful.

When should the rules be discussed? It is usually preferable to cover group rules as needed rather than opening up with a speech or discussion about them. For some groups, presenting them at the very beginning may be fine (especially for some elementary and middle school groups). However, counselors leading groups with this age need to be sensitive to starting the group with the rules. They run the risk of having the group feel like a classroom or the leader being viewed the same as the teachers in the building. Presenting the rules right at the beginning can set a negative tone if not done in a warm, positive manner.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

View again video 5.2 and watch how the leader uses his voice to set a positive tone even while going over a couple of group rules. Also note how he did not spend too much time on the rules and moved on rather quickly to the purpose of the group.

How should the rules be discussed? Any presentation or discussion of rules for the group should be done in a pleasant, positive manner. Rules regarding such things as no eating, drinking, or smoking during group sessions; attendance; and no attacking of others or putting others on the spot can be briefly discussed because they are rules that the leader has decided upon. Rules about the confidentiality of the information shared among members need more attention because it is very important that everyone understands what it means and that everyone agrees to keep things confidential. The leader will want to get some acknowledgment from each person that he or she agrees to keep material confidential. It should be noted however that confidentiality in groups cannot be guaranteed. The leader should emphasize the importance of confidentiality, and members do need to be aware of this risk.

The following examples show when and how to "sandwich" in the rules and how to focus on confidentiality.

■ EXAMPLES

It is 30 minutes into the first session of a therapy group.

JAKE: I want to hear what David thinks. He hasn't said anything about his problems.

LEADER: Let me jump in here. I know that some of you may want to hear from other members, but one rule that I have in groups that I lead is that no one will be forced to talk. So, rather than putting David on the spot, you might say that you are curious about what others are thinking. The reason for this rule is that I want people not to have to worry about being attacked or singled out. Any comments on this?

(Lets a few seconds pass) Let's go back to sharing concerns you are currently working on.

In this example, the leader saw the need to mention a rule and stated it in a natural manner. He also spared David by shifting the focus from him to the rule and then back to the topic. Introducing rules when they are relevant helps members remember them better.

■ ■ ■

This group is in the first half-hour, and the members are discussing fears about being in the group. They are using a sentence-completion form containing a sentence that reads "One thing I am afraid of in groups is _____."

Beth: I wrote that I am afraid of looking foolish.

Leader: That is a very common feeling. I would imagine that others feel the same way. *(Several heads nod)*

Fern: I wrote that I am afraid of being attacked by other members for something that I say.

Leader: I want to comment on that. I'd like to establish a rule that no one is allowed to attack another member. We are here to listen and learn from each other, not to attack those who differ from us. How do all of you feel about having that as a rule?

The leader asks the question to hold the focus on "no member will be allowed to attack another member" because she feels it is a very important issue for the group.

■ ■ ■

It is early in the middle phase of the first session, and a member says he has something he would like to bring up. It is obvious that what he is going to say is very personal, and he is the first member actually to say that he wants to talk about a concern. Up to now, members have shared only "safe" things about themselves.

John: I think I want to share something that happened while I was on patrol that I have never told anyone.

Leader: John, before you do I want to mention something very important. In the beginning, we discussed briefly that we should keep things confidential. I want to emphasize that rule because John obviously is about to share something important and personal to him. It is imperative that we keep the content of these group meetings confidential if there is to be a feeling of trust. Is this suitable to everyone? *(Looks around the room)* I am going to ask each of you if you agree to keep things confidential. Chico?

Chico: Yes.

Carlos: Yes.

Abdul: Yes.

THOMAS: I agree.

LEADER: Okay, John, let's get back to what you wanted to share.

■ ■ ■

In regard to rules, our point is that the leader should not spend an inordinate amount of time on the rules unless there is some reason to do so. If a member tries to argue about a rule that the leader feels is necessary, the leader should calmly explain why it is important for the smooth running of the group. Sometimes, it is best simply to say what the rules are and why they exist rather than opening them up for discussion. For example, if a leader decides that there will be no smoking or eating during the group, she can tell the group the reason.

LEADER: Because the room is small and some of us are nonsmokers, there will be no smoking during the session. If you feel you have to smoke, you may excuse yourself for a couple of minutes. Also, I'm going to ask you not to eat or drink during the session because it can be distracting.

■ ■ ■

A common mistake made by beginning leaders is to discuss issues like the preceding ones for 10 to 20 minutes. This is usually not necessary and detracts from the purpose of the group. In many kinds of groups, it is appropriate and helpful for the leader to decide the rules and inform the group of what they are.

Explaining Terms

If the leader plans to use special terms, she should explain them to the members. Some terms that might confuse members are *rounds, dyads,* and *exercises*. If the group is a counseling, therapy, support, or growth group, the leader will want to explain the terms she might be using, such as *private logic, REBT, TA, ego states,* or *alter ego*. The leader could explain the terms when she is explaining her role or at any other time that seems appropriate, such as the first time they naturally occur. Explaining terms and procedures in the first or second session reduces the chances of confusion or misunderstanding when they are used in later sessions.

Assessing Members' Interaction Styles

During the first session, the leader will want to note the different ways that members interact in the group. This is extremely helpful for leading the session and planning for future sessions. Every member has a certain style or manner. Some members may be very quiet; others may try to dominate; others may be supportive; and still others may be very critical. By observing these styles, the leader will be able to adjust the plan for the session. Any leader who fails to assess the interaction style of members will make the task of leading much more difficult.

Leaders assess interaction styles through paying attention to what members say, how they say it, and how often they say anything. Too often, a beginning leader will get caught up in the content of the group and fail to observe that not all members are participating or that certain members are dominating.

Being Sensitive to Multicultural and Diversity Issues and Any Dynamics That May Be Present

Diversity is a double-edged sword. The cultural, ethnic, and gender differences among members mean that there are also potential differences in values, perceptions, and communication styles. These differences can create misunderstandings among group members. For example, in many world cultures, adherence to ethnic or cultural group norms is more highly valued than are individual pursuits and desires. Thus, the simple act of speaking out in disagreement may be a near impossibility for some group members, say from Mexico, China, or Japan. Other major cultural differences that can affect group dynamics include:

- Perceptions and reactions to authority
- The extent to which intimate emotions are revealed
- The manner in which status is afforded
- The manner in which trust is developed
- The importance of time (past, present, or future emphasis)
- Locus of control (internal or external)

On the other hand, these differences, though potentially problematic, are sources of great strength and learning. It is through these very differences that group members may learn to cope in a multicultural world and to transfer new skills that were previously unattainable. Comments about the differences can be beneficial for setting a positive tone. For instance, the group leader may say something like:

Leader: One of the major benefits of groups is that there are a number of different people with different ideas and different views from yours. I think this group has a great mix of people, and I think this should make the group rich since everyone can learn from others. Some of you may even be uncomfortable with the differences, but I do believe that in the end you'll find that having people here that are different from you will be very beneficial. Does anyone want to comment about how they are feeling regarding the makeup of the group?

Comments like this can open the group up for discussion of differences. During such a discussion, the leader should listen carefully in order to get a sense of the open- or closed-mindedness of the members. If, in the first or second session, the leader hears judgmental or prejudiced comments, she should comment on how the group is made up of different people living different lifestyles and that one of the things that she will do as the leader is to make sure there is no "bashing" of anyone's beliefs or lifestyle.

Cutting Off Members During the First Session

It is very important during the first session to not let a member dominate or attack other members. If the leader does not restrain those members, others will feel intimidated or upset because they did not have a chance to contribute. The leader has to be prepared to use cutting-off skills. *Sometime during the first session, the leader should explain that he will at times be interrupting members.*

LEADER: Something that I may do from time to time is interrupt if I feel you are off on a tangent or others want to speak. Two of my tasks are to keep us focused on the purpose of the group and to give everyone a chance to talk.

Cutting off is an essential skill for group leading and a leader must be prepared to refocus any member who is being very negative or hostile or who is trying to dominate or focus the group on some irrelevant tangent. We devote most of Chapter 8 to how and when to cut off members.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS: How to Conduct a First Session

View again video 5.2. Watch how the leader explains how he may have to cut off members. Note his very warm, positive tone.

Focusing on the Content

In this book, *content* means the topic being discussed in the group. All groups have a content area. Some groups are very specific—such as assertiveness, coping with combat, or study skills; other groups are less specific, such as personal problems or personal growth. The leader will want to be sure to focus some of the first session on the content or purpose of the group. Devoting too much time in the first session to ice breakers, explaining rules, making introductions, getting acquainted, and explaining the leadership role will cause members to become bored and lose interest because their needs are not being met. To focus members on the content, the leader can use an introduction exercise that causes them to think about why they came to the group, as in the following example. As the round ends, the leader focuses on content by commenting or asking a question based on something that was said in the round.

■ EXAMPLES

It is the first session of a group of battered women. The leader has briefly discussed the purpose of the group and has had each of the five women introduce herself and tell a little about her situation. The introduction round is on the next-to-last person.

JANE: I'm Jane. I have been married for 4 years. I have two children. My husband has beaten me five times, and each time has been worse than the others. He says it is my fault—I'm confused about whether it is my fault.

DIANE: I'm Diane. My husband verbally and physically abuses me daily. I have been in counseling, but I always seem to let him sweet-talk me into going back with him.

LEADER: Diane, that's a good topic that we will discuss later. I was thinking that for now a good theme to talk about may be the one that Jane and a number of others alluded to about being confused about whose fault it is. I know many women often do think it is their fault that their partner gets so out of control. What thoughts or feelings do any of you have about whether you think it is your fault?

In this example, the leader focuses the group on an important topic that everyone has feelings about. The discussion could last for 10 to 20 minutes and probably would be very helpful because it is a topic that is definitely relevant for all the members.

■ ■ ■

The purpose of this group is to provide help for students who are close to being expelled from school and are concerned about it. The members are discussing their expectations of the group.

BARRY: I hope that people here can help me stay out of trouble. I really want to stay in school—I like being with my friends.

LEADER: I think what Barry is saying applies to all of you—that you want to stay in school. Is that right? *(Sees all the heads nodding)* Let's talk then about what it's going to take to stay out of trouble. What do you need to do to keep yourself out of trouble? Who wants to comment on that?

RICO: I will. I realize that I have got to ... *(A valuable discussion follows for the next 10 minutes about all the things that can help them stay out of trouble: doing schoolwork, not talking during class, not fighting, hanging out with different friends, and attending the group.)*

LEADER: A while back, we were going over expectations and took off on what Barry said. Does anyone else have an expectation for this group that hasn't been discussed?

MARTHA: I do. I hope that the group can be a place where I can learn to say, "no!" I really need to learn this.

LEADER: That's a good thing to learn, and I think we can talk about that in here. How many of you also have trouble saying "no"? *(Looks around)* Seems like quite a few. We have about 15 minutes left; let's talk about that for a few minutes. I'd like you to think about who is the

hardest person for you to say "no" to. We'll go around the group and get each of you to comment. Your friends? Your siblings? Your parents?

■ ■ ■

In each of the preceding examples, the leader has skillfully focused the group on some interesting topics. Another way to move from the process to the content is to introduce an issue or present some information. In a task group, the leader might say, "Why don't we start by discussing the options that are available?" One other way to make the transition from process to content is to use a group exercise.

Addressing Questions

In the first session, members will sometimes have a wide variety of questions that they want answered. Some of their questions will pertain to the purpose of the group, others to the meeting time and place, the leader's credentials, and other details. A common mistake occurs when leaders do not anticipate these possible questions and fail to allot time for members to ask what they consider to be important questions. Answering questions is good, but it is very important that the leader does not allow the first session to become a question-and-answer session. It is also a leadership mistake to take a long time to answer a question that only one member is interested in. If the leader feels too much time is being spent on specific questions that are not relevant to all the members, she can offer to stay and answer additional questions when the session ends.

Getting Members to Look at Other Members

Often, members will speak mainly to the leader unless the leader encourages them to talk to the entire group. *Getting members to look at other members is absolutely essential* because it is helpful in involving members, building group cohesion, and creating an atmosphere of belonging. To get members to look at the entire group or to get them to avoid looking only at you, any or all of the following are appropriate:

- Tell your members you would like them to look at the group rather than exclusively at you when they are talking. You can explain this in the beginning or after someone has spoken directly to you. Ask the person talking and the rest of the members to look at everyone in the group.
- Explain to the members that you are not going to be looking at them all the time when they are speaking because at various times you will be scanning the group. You can also tell them to let your scanning serve as a signal to them to address the entire group.
- Scan the group, because the talking member will tend to seek eye contact with someone; if you are scanning, the speaker will usually look elsewhere.

- Signal the member to talk to everyone by making a sweeping motion with your hand. A sweeping motion consists of bringing your right hand to your left shoulder and then bringing it slowly around until it is more or less pointing to your right.

EXAMPLES

Ten minutes into a first session.

LEADER: *(With a kind, gentle voice)* Let me comment on something that just happened and has been happening here during the first few moments of our session. Kim was mainly looking at me during the time she was talking about her problems with her son because I am the leader. Others have also been doing this. What I'd like you to do is to look at others when you talk instead of looking at me, because everyone is interested in what each of you has to say. You will also notice that when you are talking, I may be scanning the group. I will do this for three reasons: to see how others are reacting, to see who seems as if they want to speak, and also to remind you to look at others in the group. Anyone have questions about that?

KIM: I did notice you looking away at times and I was thinking you were being kind of rude. I am glad you clarified that.

LEADER: For some of you, it may take some getting used to, and I may even signal you with my hand to get you to look around.

■ ■ ■

It is the second session, and the leader remembered that the teenage members tended to talk to her only.

LEADER: Let's start. Remember, I will be scanning the room with my eyes. Do you recall what I told you last session about why I am doing this?

WILSON: You want us to look at everyone when we talk and not just you!

LEADER: That's right. Why else?

ROSS: You are not only listening to us when we talk but you are observing others' reactions.

LEADER: Good. So today, try real hard to look at everyone, and if you see me not looking at you when you are talking, take that as a signal to look around. Any comments or thoughts about our first session or observations during this week?

■ ■ ■

It should be mentioned that there will be times when the leader will want a member to address another member specifically. This occurs when a member

has a question, concern, or feedback for a specific member. The leader may need to encourage the member to look at the member he is addressing.

Other First-Session Considerations

In many kinds of groups, the opportunity may arise during the first session to focus on one member's ideas, opinions, stories, or concerns. In certain education, discussion, and task groups, it is very appropriate to allow the focus to be held on one issue for an extended period of time. However, in most support, growth, counseling, and therapy groups, it is usually not a good idea to spend more than 10–15 minutes focused on one member. The purpose of the first session is to give members a chance to share their concerns and to get to know one another. Focusing on one member may cause others to feel left out. Another reason to be careful when focusing on a member during the first session is that members may not be ready for in-depth therapy during the first session.

Discussion of certain topics may be inappropriate for the first session. Beginning leaders can err by focusing on any topic that arises or focusing on issues that require more trust and comfort than is present in a first session. For instance, in a group for helping members find employment after military service, the leader would not want to focus on how to present oneself during an interview but rather would probably want to focus the group on skills assessment or how to locate places of potential employment. How to interview is a good topic but should not be discussed until later. Other inappropriate topics for the first session of a growth or therapy group might be sexual issues or death. Usually the leader should wait at least two or three sessions before introducing topics such as these.

Closing the First Session

Closing the first session is similar to closing any other session except that the leader will want to allow more time to hear members' reactions and clear up any questions or other matters that need clarifying. Depending on the kind of group, the leader may want to ask some of the following questions during the closing phase of the first session.

- How was the session for you?
- How was being here different from what you thought was going to happen?
- What stood out to you?
- Was there anything that happened that you didn't understand or didn't like?
- Do you have questions about the group, its purpose, or what is going to happen?
- What did you learn from group today?

During the close of the first session, the leader will probably want to summarize the session and comment again on the purpose of the group and what the possibilities are for the future.

Evaluation of the First Session

After the end of the first session the leader should assess the success of the group. If the first session did not go smoothly, the leader will want to assess why. The following are possible reasons for an unsuccessful first session:

- Members were afraid to talk or share.
- Members were confused about the purpose of the group.
- The group was held at a bad time of day.
- Members came late and disrupted the group.
- Diversity or gender issues inhibited members from fully participating.
- The leader was unclear about the purpose of the group or the members' needs.
- The room was not conducive to groups.
- Members were forced to attend the group.
- Members reacted negatively to the leader.
- The session was not planned well.
- The focus moved from topic to topic too quickly.
- The focus was held on a person or topic too long.
- Too much or too little time was spent on warming up.

Much thought needs to go into planning a second session when the first session did not go well. It may be necessary to ask certain members not to return because they are not appropriate for the group. The leader may need to change the setting, meeting time, or content. Unfortunately, many beginning leaders do not take the time to fully understand why the group did not go well, and they go to the second session with no significant changes from the first session.

The Second Session

The leader continues setting the tone of the group during the second session, being aware that some members may still be uncomfortable. In addition, the leader needs to give thought to the following issues:

- Opening the second session
- Planning for a potential letdown
- Ending the second session

Opening the Second Session

Two important considerations for opening the second session are the introduction of new members and the evaluation of the first session's success.

Introducing New Members If new members join the group, it is usually a good idea to begin with introductions. Several methods can be used. In the example below, the leader introduces the new member in a manner that gives that person an opportunity to hear what happened in the previous session as well as to get to know the names of other members. This type of introduction also serves as a review for the other members.

LEADER: This is Ralph. He was unable to make our meeting last week. I thought as a way to update Ralph, I'd ask you to share one or two things that stood out to you about what we discussed last week. Be sure to say your name, also.

This method can be combined with one that gives the new members a chance to share their own situations. For instance, at the beginning of a recovery group, the leader could say:

LEADER: As a review, I thought we'd start by having each of you share how your week was; and because Carol is new, you may want to comment on what was most helpful last week in the group. Also share your name.

At the end of this round, the leader could say something like:

LEADER: Carol, if you feel comfortable, you may want to share some of your story, or you may want to wait until later. It's up to you.

Certain kinds of groups will require no planning beyond having new members give their names and a little information about themselves.

■ EXAMPLE

LEADER: *(After asking members to get settled for the beginning of the group)* There are two new members joining us today. I have asked them to tell us their names and some relevant information about themselves.

MELVIN: My name is Melvin Conrad, and I'm glad to be here. I am new in town. My family moved here from New York.

LEADER: Okay, Melvin. *(Looks toward Rhonda)*

RHONDA: My name is Rhonda. I am here because I want to get over my fear of people, and my counselor said this was a good place to do that.

This is perhaps the simplest and briefest method of introducing new members. After the new members give a brief introduction, a round can be used where the other group members tell their names.

Another method of introduction is for the leader to tell the group about the new members. This can be done only if the leader has had the opportunity to meet with the new members before the session has begun. A leader might choose this approach: (1) to minimize the time spent on the introduction, (2) to tell the group something specific about the member that the member

might not include in the self-introduction, or (3) to ease in a new member who is very anxious about speaking in front of the group. For example, if a new member is frightened, the leader might say:

LEADER: This is Ted. He's going to be joining the group. Ted told me that he was really apprehensive about coming today, so I told him that he would not have to say anything if he didn't want to. Let's start by talking about any thoughts or reactions to last week's session. What thoughts or feelings did you have about coming back the second time? I'd like each of you to share something and also state your name.

The amount of time spent introducing new members will often depend on the kind of group. In most counseling, therapy, growth, and support groups, an introduction activity of 5 minutes or less is all that is necessary for new members. During this time new members can tell the group their names and a little bit about why they are there, what their interests are, and what they hope to gain from being part of the group. In task, discussion, and education groups, merely having new members give their names may be sufficient.

When new members come to the second session, the leader must decide how much time should be spent informing them of what happened during the previous session. Informing new members of the events of the first session helps them adjust more quickly to the group; however, if there is a lot to explain, the leader should try to do so before the second session to prevent boring the returning members with a lengthy recap of the first session.

■ ■ ■

The Success of the First Session If the first session was reasonably successful and a positive tone was set, the leader will plan a brief warm-up and then move on to the content. On the other hand, if the first session did not go successfully, the leader may choose from three options: (1) restate the purpose of the group and make no attempt to verbalize any of the negative events of the first session; (2) address what went wrong in an effort to explain that future sessions will not be similar to the first one; or (3) elicit from members their reactions to the first session. By addressing what went wrong, the leader acknowledges that the first session was not a good one and can point out ways that the group can be better.

■ EXAMPLES

LEADER: Okay, let's get started. I'm glad you are back. I thought our first session went fairly well and I truly believe each session will get better as we get to know each other. I'd like to start with this activity to get us all focused on why we are here and how this group can be helpful.

■ ■ ■

LEADER: Okay, let's get started. I'd like to say something about the first session. When the group ended the other night, I was concerned that some of you may have left feeling discouraged. I realize that not enough people got to share because we focused so much on a couple of you. As we were wrapping up, I sensed that some of you felt a bit frustrated because you asked if every group was going to be like this and whether you would get a chance to talk. Let me assure you that not every group will be like the first one. All of you signed up to be in this group because you felt a need to get support and hear ideas from people who are struggling with the same issues that you are. I know that the group will be most beneficial if you share your thoughts and feelings concerning your common situations. I will make sure that the group does not focus on only one or two members unless the majority of you indicate a desire to do so.

■ ■ ■

LEADER: I want to begin this session by getting your reaction to the last one. I feel that our first session was okay, but I do believe these next sessions can be better. Please share honestly any reactions or questions that you had about what we did here last time.

In this example, the leader gives the members a chance to react so that he can comment on their reactions in a positive, clarifying manner.

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Our point is that the leader needs to consider the success of the first session when planning the second session. The leader will also want to remember that it is usually necessary and helpful to reiterate the purpose of the group during the second session. If the group did not go well, the leader will definitely need to plan to counteract the bad beginning. One leader we know decided to use name tags on the chairs to break up the cliques of eighth-grade girls. She knew she could have a good group, but the first session did not go well because of where the girls were sitting. She assigned seats for the next few sessions and had a very successful group.

It is also helpful, when possible, for the leader to arrive at the second session early and talk informally to members before the group begins. This provides some idea of how members reacted to the first session. It also gives the leader a chance to answer members' questions about the group and to get to know the members a little bit better.

Planning for the Potential Letdown

A skilled leader will anticipate a letdown during the second session. A common mistake of beginning leaders is to think that the excitement exhibited among members during the first session is always present in the second session. He often fails to anticipate that there may be a different energy for the second session.

One reason for the change in the members' energy is that much of the first session is spent on members getting acquainted with each other, discussing why they are there, what their expectations are, and the format and rules for the group. Given these topics, first sessions can be filled with a lot of sharing and excitement. In the second session, the focus moves toward personal sharing, and members often experience anxiety about participating. They become hesitant to interact, thus causing a letdown, which can often be disconcerting to a beginning group leader. To help prevent the letdown, the leader can mention at the beginning of the second session that members may not feel as enthusiastic as the first time and may feel a little apprehensive. *The most important thing a leader can do to prevent the letdown is plan a good session based on what she learned from the first session.*

Ending the Second Session

The leader should plan to spend an extra few minutes ending the second session. During the closing phase, the leader will want to hear what the members perceive as being helpful and unhelpful. A round asking the members to describe their positive and negative reactions to the group is a very valuable closing activity.

EXAMPLES

LEADER: Let's take a few minutes to wind up the group. We're going to do a round in just a moment. I would like each of you to share what stands out to you the most about being in this group. In addition, if there is anything that you would like to see us do differently, please say so.

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LEADER: I want to take some time to end the group today so that I can get some idea of how you are feeling about being in this group thus far. Think of how you would rate this group on a 1–10 scale. *(Leader explains the meaning of the scale)* If your rating is not a 10, think what it would take to move the group up to a 10.

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In both of these examples, the leader would spend time discussing the various responses, clarifying anything that needed clarification, and answering any questions.

The Beginning Phase of Subsequent Sessions

We want to close this chapter by discussing the beginning phase of sessions after the initial two sessions. Every session has a beginning, or warm-up, phase and leaders should always consider how they are going to open each session.

The leader has a number of options for beginning a session. Any of the options described below may be used, depending on the group's purpose and the members' need for warming up. As you will note, some of the options get right to the point, whereas others allow for sharing time, comments, or updates. Also, a leader may use more than one option during the warm-up phase of a session.

Education or Discussion Groups

- Before we get started on today's subject, does anyone have any questions or comments about last week or about the handout I gave you?
- Today, we are going to talk about _____. To get you thinking about the subject, I'd like you to do the following....
- I'd like to talk for a few minutes about _____, and then we'll discuss your reactions, feelings, and thoughts.
- We're going to start with a 15-minute film. Afterward, we'll discuss any questions or reactions.

Task Groups

- Let's start with progress reports from each of you. Who wants to go first?
- Let me review briefly where we are and what seems to be the next thing we need to decide.
- Before we start, do any of you have something pertinent you want to share?

Growth or Support Groups

- How has the week been?
- Any reactions to the last session, progress reports, or updates?
- What would you like to talk about tonight—any particular topic or issue you would like to discuss?
- Let's start by thinking about the most significant thing that has happened to you since our last meeting. In a minute, we'll go around and let each of you share this. Who wants to go first? We'll hear from everyone.

Counseling or Therapy Groups

- Let's begin. Last session, a number of you talked about some very important personal issues. I think it would be good if you shared any reactions or thoughts you've had since then. We might do that for a few minutes and then move on to other people and topics.
- I want to start the group a little differently. I want each of you to think about whether you have something you would like to talk about. In a second, we'll go around the room. I'm going to have you simply say yes

or no if there is something you would like to address or not. This is just a quick way to find out how many of you have something on your mind. I hope many of you will have something you want to discuss, but it is perfectly okay to say no.

- Why don't we start? First, does anyone have something they'd like to bring up?
- Let's start. What is a word or phrase that describes the week for you? Let's do a round starting with you, Roberta. You look like you're ready.
- Let's start. I was talking with Sammy out in the hall just now, and he said he had something that was really bothering him. I hope we can help. Sammy, you said you wanted to tell the group what happened when you saw your dad.

In the last example, the leader decided to stray from her planned opening because she realized that focusing on Sammy would be a good way to begin the group, plus Sammy had told the leader he wanted her to focus on him. The leader knew what Sammy had to work on was very relevant to the purpose and would take quite a bit of time. In this situation, the leader would want to proceed quickly and then see if others had any pressing concerns to discuss. Sometimes, skipping the warm-up phase can be a mistake (as discussed later in this chapter), but in this last example the leader made a good decision to skip it.

Creative Activities for the Beginning Phase

The leader must always be thinking about the warm-up phase and the best way to start the session. With school groups—especially elementary school groups—time is limited and the kids can be excited and wound up. In one school, this situation was handled in a very interesting and effective way. The group consisted of six very energetic, active sixth-grade girls. The leader had the members sit in a tight circle. She placed a garbage can in the center and had all the members lean in toward the garbage can and talk about what was on their minds, all at the same time. Every member talked feverishly into the trash can about whatever was bothering them. After a couple of minutes, the leader stopped them and "officially" started the group. This seemed to calm the members to start the session. There are times when the leader may want to get the members' attention by using a dramatic movie clip, a song, or a reading.

Mistakes During the Beginning Phase

Leaders sometimes make one of two mistakes regarding the beginning phase: (1) They let it go on too long by allowing the warm-up to stray from the purpose, or (2) they skip it and don't allow time for members to warm up. A good warm-up phase gets members to transition from their lives outside of group to being present and available for group interaction.

EXAMPLES

The group is meeting to work on anger control. This warm-up phase gets away from the leader.

LEADER: How was the week?

RICK: *(In a slow, storytelling voice)* Mine was very hectic. It started on Tuesday, no, it was Monday. I was walking to school on Jones Avenue and then I went by the site where they are building the new mall. They have the list of stores that are going to be in the mall. There is going to be a Wal-Mart, Sears, and a whole bunch of other neat stores. My mom and I went to the old Wal-Mart and I thought it was big. This one is going to be much bigger, or so my mom says. Anyhow when I turned on Jefferson Street there was a little dog on a leash just like my grandfather's dog. This started me thinking about my grandfather and how much I miss him. So when I got to school, I decided I would go by the office and call him. When I went to the office, I ran into Toni and Sara.

SHERRY: I know Toni and Sara. Sara is actually my second cousin. I spent last Thanksgiving with Sara. I think she is so cool. On Thanksgiving we ...

ALISHA: I heard this Wal-Mart is going to be the biggest in the state! I like Wal-Mart because ...

In this group, the warm-up phase could last a very long time, with members getting into stories and topics not relevant to the purpose of the group.

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Here is the same group, but the leader gets the members back on track.

LEADER: How was the week? Anything come up that you think is relevant to what we have been talking about?

RICK: *(In a slow, storytelling voice)* Mine was very hectic. It started on Tuesday, no, it was Monday. I was walking to school on Jones Avenue and then I went by the site where they are building the new mall. They have the list of stores that are going to be in the mall.

LEADER: *(Knowing that Rick tends to tell long, irrelevant stories)* Rick, briefly what happened that relates to this group?

RICK: Oh, I was just going to tell a funny story about getting my books mixed up with Toni's. That's all.

LEADER: Anyone have something to discuss that fits with what we have been talking about?

HEIDI: I do....

Note the leader's question at the beginning is a little more specific, and he quickly intervenes when it becomes evident that Rick is about to go into an

irrelevant story. Often beginning leaders do not pay enough attention to the opening few minutes of a group; thus, the group gets off in the wrong direction and valuable time is wasted.

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In the following example, the leader skips the warm-up. As we mentioned, it is usually a mistake to fail to allow a minute or so to hear if anyone has something relevant he wants to say.

LEADER: Let's begin.

TRISH: I start working at the cash register on Monday and I'm a little nervous.

DAN: I was nervous when I first had to work the cash register.

SKIP: I got in serious trouble at work this week when I ran the cash register.

LEADER: Trish, say some more about being nervous.

In this example, the leader starts working with Trish before hearing from the others who may have important concerns. The leader should hear more about the trouble Skip got into and from others.

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Concluding Comments

The first and second sessions set the tone for the other sessions. One very important component of the first session is how the leader opens the session. The leader has many choices. During the first session, the leader needs to pay attention to both content (what the group is about) and process (the interactions, comfort level, attitudes of members, etc.). It is important that the leader not focus too long on one person during the first sessions. The leader wants to set a positive tone and make sure the group is interesting and engaging.

Rules, such as no put-downs or attacking other members, confidentiality, and attendance, need to be covered during the first session. Often, the best way to cover the rules is to let them emerge as the session unfolds. It is usually not necessary to spend much time on the rules.

In planning for the second session, the leader needs to be prepared for a potential letdown. If the first session did not go well, the leader will want to specifically prepare to counteract any negative reactions. Also, the leader often may want to spend extra time closing the first and second sessions to get reactions and answer questions.

The beginning phase of all sessions should be given considerable thought. There are a number of options for opening a session, plus the leader may want to use creative openings at times. The two most common mistakes during the beginning phase are letting the warm-up last too long or skipping the warm-up altogether. Leaders should always be aware of how they are going to start their groups.

■ ACTIVITIES

1. Think of four different groups. Plan the opening few minutes of each of them. Then go back and read the first few pages of this chapter and see if you have the best opening for the given group.
2. Think of at least two groups or classes where a good tone was set. What did the leader or teacher do to create that tone?
3. Think of at least two groups or classes where the tone was bad. What did the leader or teacher do to create that tone?
4. Think of two unique, creative openings of groups that you anticipate leading in your counseling career.



GROUP COUNSELING SKILLS

1. View again video 5.1.
   a. What kind of tone would have been set if the leader had let the first member talk about her anti-war feelings?
   b. How did the leader help the male member feel comfortable?
2. View again video 5.2.
   a. What did the leader do to set a very comfortable tone, even though he covered leadership concepts like the use of eyes and cutting off?
   b. How did the leader get members focused on the purpose?
3. View video 5.3.
   a. How did the rounds help set a positive tone?
   b. Why was the sentence completion helpful?
   c. What were all the things the leader did to set a very positive tone?